



The Sixty Years' Quarrel

Antients, Moderns, and the Union of 1813

LORE

Two rival Grand Lodges, sixty years of mutual non-recognition, and the settlement that made our ritual what it is. Explains more about why we do what we do than any other single subject.

ON THE TABLE

The Lodge warrant, and its number



HRH the Duke of Sussex, Grand Master of the Moderns and first Grand Master of the United Grand Lodge, by Thomas Phillips — Thomas Phillips
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HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
1:30	Part One: 1717, and a word of caution
4:00	Part Two: 1751, and the insult of a lifetime
7:00	Part Three: Laurence Dermott
9:30	Part Four: what they actually argued about
13:00	Part Five: sixty years, and two brothers
15:30	Part Six: the settlement
18:30	Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The Antients named their rivals the Moderns, and the insult has stuck for 270 years.
- 2 Deacons and the Royal Arch are Antient inheritances; the administrative shape is largely Moderns.
- 3 The union of 1813 was settled by two royal brothers, and lodge numbers were interleaved by drawing lots.



IF YOU ARE ASKED

Who were the Antients?

A rival Grand Lodge formed in 1751, largely by Irish masons in London, claiming to preserve older practice.

Why are the older body called Moderns?

Because the Antients named them that, as an insult, and it stuck for 270 years.

What did they disagree about?

Transposed words in the first two degrees, deacons, the Royal Arch, the Installed Master ceremony, saints' days, Christian references.

Who was Laurence Dermott?

Antients' Grand Secretary from 1752; author of Ahiman Rezon, 1756. The most effective polemicist we ever produced.

When and how did it end?

27 December 1813. The two Grand Masters were brothers — Sussex (Moderns) and Kent (Antients) — and Kent stood down.

Why is our number what it is?

The 1813 union interleaved both registers by drawing lots, with further renumberings in 1832 and 1863.

Is 1717 reliable?

Treat it with care. Our source is Anderson writing in 1738; modern scholarship questions the tidy version.

SOURCES

- Articles of Union, 1813 — printed in the Book of Constitutions
- Laurence Dermott, Ahiman Rezon, 1756
- James Anderson, The Constitutions of the Free-Masons, 1723 and 1738
- John Hamill, The Craft: A History of English Freemasonry
- Ric Berman, The Foundations of Modern Freemasonry — on the 1717 question
- Andrew Prescott, papers on the origins of Grand Lodge
- Ars Quatuor Coronatorum — the Lodge of Reconciliation and the 1813 settlement

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

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